

Love Conquers All

"With all their recklessness, Roxanne's eyes gleamed up at Charles. A sun that set red in the smoky west touched them kindly and gilded their handsome silhouettes against a burned-out ruined city, that would soon rise Phoenix-like from the ashes. Just as they would rise anew from the ashes of their shattered, misspent lives and bask in the joy and brightness of their new love..."

That first night out, a sliver of moon scattered diamonds over the waters...Roxanne turned to Charles languorously. Roxanne lay on her back in the bunk, the moonlight silvering her lovely body. Fondly, she watched Charles undress, toss his clothes to a chair. In matching silver perfection, he stood above her for a moment, smiling down.

And then Charles, for whom a loving fate had fashioned her, was in her arms again. He nuzzled her throat, his rich soft laugh rang in her ears. She sighed deeply and her pliant body melted against his own as she surrendered herself to the night, to the magic, to the man she would always love." (adapted from "That Barrington Woman" – Valerie Sherwood)

Ahhhh. Isn't that romantic? True love. It overcomes all obstacles. It reunites those who are apart. It keeps together those that are together. It is the foundation of all that is good and beautiful and true.

It was the ancient Greek poet and philosopher Virgil who wrote these immortal words in his tenth eclogue. "Love conquers all things. Let us too surrender to love."

Think of the power of Love. From childhood we have been taught its stories. Remember "Beauty and the Beast?" A young woman is forced to wed a horrible creature. But, it is through her love, steadfast, patient, and powerful, that the beast becomes a prince. Love turns him around. Love conquers all.

Think about the people you know, including yourself. How many do you know who have been saved by love? A person, lost, broken, in despair, trapped, or in some way living in pain. Yet a teacher, a church community, a parent, someone, loved, hard enough, deep enough, and long enough, for healing and hope to happen. Love conquers all.

And of course, religion tells us this in exquisite detail. Christianity is based on love. "For God so loved the world that the Son of God was given so that whosoever believes in him may not perish, but have eternal life." Our mistakes, our trespasses, our failures, and our sins are all forgiven. Grace is bestowed upon us. We are saved, because of love.

The ancient Greeks had four different names for love. "Eros" meaning Romantic love or sexual desire. "Philia" meaning friendship or a platonic love. "Storge" meaning natural affection. And "Agape" meaning an unconditional love and often associated with the Divine.

Our English language is a bit more limited. We speak of love and talk of the commitment and power of a marriage or partnership, "I love my wife." We speak of love and we express our passion and dedication to our work or a cause. "I love making a difference in this world." We speak of love and announce our affection for our family, our friends, and our pets. "I love my new puppy." We even speak of love and proclaim our preference for particular activities and things. "I love chocolate, reading, and long walks by the lakes."

We really are quite focused on love. Studies have been conducted and theories set forth about what makes us fall in love. Questions have been raised – is love a conscious choice, a force in and of itself, a chemical reaction, or is it just how we are hard-wired as humans?

Yet over and over, in our faith, in our literature, in our entertainment, and in our hopes and dreams, love conquers all. We are taught that no matter the troubles we face or the hardships we endure, no matter the bumps and tragedies in our lives and relationships, love will win out. And if not in this life, love will definitely win in what follows.

Without love, we are nothing. Riches, good deeds, even acts of giving, are empty without love. The apostle Paul writes one of the most famous descriptions of love. Surely you have heard:

I Corinthians 13:1-13

If I speak in the tongues of mortals and of angels, but do not have love, I am a noisy gong or a clanging cymbal. And if I have prophetic powers, and understand all mysteries and all knowledge, and if I have all faith, so as to remove mountains, but do not have love, I am nothing. If I hand over my body so that I may boast, but do not have love, I gain nothing.

Love is patient; love is kind; love is not envious or boastful or arrogant or rude. It does not insist on its own way; it is not irritable or resentful; it does not rejoice in wrongdoing, but rejoices in the truth. It bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things.

Love never ends. But as for prophecies, they will come to an end; as for tongues, they will cease; as for knowledge, it will come to an end. For we know in part; but when the complete comes, the partial will come to an end.

When I was a child, I spoke like a child, I thought like a child, I reasoned like a child; when I became an adult, I put an end to childish ways. For now we see in a mirror, dimly, but then we will see face to face. Now I know only in part; then I will know fully, even as I have been fully known. And now faith, hope, and love abide, these three; and the greatest of these is love.

At the center, the very core of our existence, is love. If we love right, if we love well, if we love deeply and with integrity, we can not help but win. Love conquers all.

Let me offer you a different interpretation. There is a wonderful engraving by Agostino Carracci. On the right side of the picture are two naked women. On the left side, a baby boy with wings is beating up a much larger and more muscular satyr. "This image represents a pun derived from a famous line in Virgil's tenth *Eclogue*, "Love conquers all." The Latin word *omnia*, like the Greek word *pan*, signifies "all," while *amor*, the Latin name for Cupid, means "love," so that Cupid's victorious combat with the woodland god is a visual translation of the phrase."

In other words, instead of us, as humans and children of God victorious over all through love, it may be instead that we are the ones conquered by love.

I'll let that sink in a minute. Ask yourself, have you ever been dominated by love?

Let me pause here. I am not talking about some unhealthy, obsessive, co-dependent experience that is often labeled as love. I am not referring to the type of emotions and experiences written about in books such as Women Who Love Too Much and Co-Dependent No More, or so many of the love songs one hears on the radio. The love that I'm speaking of is sound and solid. And while it does involve our intellect and our will, it also overcomes us.

Which of your loves did you intentionally choose? Did you carefully compare your husband, wife, or partner to all the other possible mates available to you and decide, "Yes. I believe I will love this one"? Or did you find yourself falling in love, and then needing to make some decisions about that? How many of you in this room, when you first held your grand baby made an intentional choice to fall in love with that child. There are hundreds of young babies out there in the world. Yet over and over again I hear grandparents tell me that they have been surprised by the depth and immediacy of the love they have for their own grandbabies. They had no choice. They were overcome by love.

We find ourselves in love. It is not an emotion or an affection that we determine. How impossible it is to make oneself fall in love when the mind says "Yes, here is a logical choice" and the heart just says "No." And if you have ever tried to make another person love you, you have experienced the futility of that. Love will not be persuaded, pressed, or purchased. We are not in command of love. Love takes hold of us.

If you have not been in control of which people you will love, have you had more say in which causes, activities, or passions you choose? Do those who love hunting and fishing decide that this would be a good thing to love? Do people who dedicate themselves to saving the earth, working for justice, or going into the ministry do so because it would be a smart move? Or woodworking, or horseback riding, or creating art, or zealous study or research. While most people might say that they chose these things, it may be more accurate to say that they were chosen. For some reason, who knows why, this person fell in love

with gardening and that one fell in love with religious studies. It was not a calculated inclination. The love caught them.

So the first part of understanding that “Love conquers all” is coming to terms with the reality that we rarely determine whom or what we will love. The choice instead is how we will act on that love.

Love begins as a feeling, taking hold of us. And then love matures into an act of the will. Scott Peck wrote, “Love, then, is a form of work or a form of courage. Specifically, it is work or courage directed toward the nurture of our own or another’s spiritual growth.”

Those wonderful, giddy, attractive, discombobulating, and powerful feelings of love do not always last. While love may grab us by the heart and direct our affection, we still have to decide how we will handle that affection. We decide what to do when we feel in love. And we decide what to do when we do not feel in love. And when we act for love, we are stretched.

“Love is that unexplainable emotion causing us to save the choice piece of meat for him, or take the other egg because it wasn’t fried just right, or wear the same old suit so she can have a nice dress, or sit in a cold car in the school yard until 3 am waiting for the bus to bring the kids back from a ball game” – Harry Wayne Addison – adapted.

Love teaches us what it really means to trust another with your heart and with your life. And to care for another even as you would care for yourself. It is not always romance and roses. Sometimes it is work and sometimes the stretching is painful. Yet it is only within a commitment to love that people truly have the freedom to evolve. And love will enlarge us and change us in ways nothing else can.

Thus love is an invitation to transcend the human condition. For in stepping beyond the self-focus of wanting to have only our own needs met, in schooling ourselves in the experience of putting another human being and his or her needs in a position of equal value to our own, we touch the web of transcendence, the presence of the divine.

To a large extent, who and what we love determines who we are.

So first love takes us by the heart, and the soul, and the mind, and the body, and decides the direction of our passions and attractions. And then, love gives us the will and ability to stay, when it would be easier to walk away. Love pushes and pulls and stretches and sometimes breaks us. We love, not by our will, but by Love’s. And we grow beyond ourselves, because love changes us.

Our sentimental and romantic mantra that “Love conquers all” is not testament to the power of our love. We are not the ones doing the conquering. It is love that instead has captured us.

Having come this far, now let’s add some theology. In many theistic religions, God, however God is understood, is often understood as the essence of love. The Holy is love in its purest form, unconditional, expansive, universal, available to all who ask. The Divine is the ocean that accepts all rivers. Nothing

can separate us from the love of God. We are kept safe in the love of the Spirit. And even we ourselves are overcome by God's great love. Love conquers all.

And we could stop here. This whole idea of Love conquering us gives us plenty to think about. Applying it to our faith adds even another dimension. But there is more. However, for those of you that are "Full -up" you can stop here!

There is a theological precept which states that God is also changed by love. Rather than the image of God as distant and unchanging, God is so closely connected with creation, so intimately involved with the people God loves, that God is also affected. God, too, is transformed and stretched.

For many people this idea is uncomfortable. Folks growing up in a Judeo-Christian society often learn of God in relation to the big four – Omnipotent, Omniscient, Omnipresent, and Immutable.

I find this interesting. Those religions relying on the Hebrew Testament and the New Testament often say that God doesn't change. God is immutable. And this is a belief many people hold. Yet in the Bible, we read time and again of instances where God seems to change. God says that punishment will come, and then forgives. Jesus states that he is here only to save the Jews, yet is persuaded to heal the Samaritan woman's daughter. The angry and jealous God of the Old Testament becomes the loving and grace giving God of the New Testament.

Now for all the places in the Bible where it seems that God changes, we have basically three options for making sense of this. The first is that we say God does not change, God already knew what was going to happen. So God was just testing the people. The second option is to decide again that God does not change. However, it is we humans who grow and change and gain a better understanding of God. Thus it seems like God is changing when it is really only us. And the third approach is to say that God does change. This is one piece of Process Theology. God is so profoundly involved with us and the world that God is willing to change and grow along with us. God is moved by the same power of love.

Process Theology stems from the work done in quantum physics. There is a new understanding about the connection of all things. Nothing is singular and isolated. Merely observing an object changes it. Our UU principles fit right into this. We "respect the interdependent web of all existence of which we are a part."

Process is a relational philosophy. There have been various relational ways of talking about the world since way back when," but most philosophers talked as if the ideal thing should be something solid that doesn't depend on anything beyond itself. To be in relation was considered a lesser value than total self sufficiency. In the 20th century we began to see that the ability to relate to another wasn't just a happenstance of the way things are, but is the core of the way things are. To exist is to be in relation. Does God exist? If you say yes, then God must also be in relation. To whom? To everyone and everything!

The philosophy takes relationship a little bit further. Process thinking says that to be related to something is to be internally affected by that something, and to affect something else in turn. Relationship is itself a dynamic process! To exist is to be affected by others, and to have an effect on others. Again, does God exist? If you answer yes, then God is affected by others, and has effects on others. Which others? All others! - Marjorie Hewitt Suchocki

Let that idea sink in for a moment. The Divine is so closely connected to us and this world that the Holy One changes too. Rather than having everything all mapped out and known, God is along for the same ride as we are, just perhaps not having the same perspective we do. The Holy is so in love with the universe that risks are taken and the exact future unknown. We are all very much in this process together. Even God.

I started this sermon by reading to you part of a very cheesy romance. The implication is what we have all been taught. With enough love, we will win over anything. Yet the artist in the middle ages may have been closer to the truth. Little cupid winning out over the big satyr; the women defenseless in his mission. Love is the victor. We are not the ones in charge. Even God is influenced by the power of love.

Love conquers all.

Virgil offered us the best course of action when we are faced with this powerful force.

"Love conquers all things; let us too surrender to love."

Amen and Amen.



Omnia vincit Amor, 1599

Agostino Carracci (Italian, Bolognese, 1557–1602)

Engraving; Plate: 5 x 7 3/8 in. (12.7 x 18.8 cm); sheet: 5 1/8 x 7 5/8 in. (13 x 19.3 cm)

Harris Brisbane Dick Fund, 1917 (17.3.1853)